Backgrounds

When included, backgrounds help you create a more believable character. Work with your DM to determine an appropriate background for your character.

Background: Doctor

Whether you were a tribal witch-doctor, a medicine-man, a holy healer, a military field medic, or a genuine medical professional from an unusually enlightened society, you specialize in the treatment of suffering. You have seen injury, disease, poison, and death, and still you have defied it all, fighting to save every last soul.

As a medical professional, you have sworn the Hippocratic oath and do your best to adhere to its tenets. In so swearing, you have pledged your life to protect life, that all who suffer are your patient, to support other doctors as family, to train any who swear the oath, to practice to the best of your ability, to always improve upon the art, to practice only your specialization, to practice not for your own gain, to practice within the law, and to keep all of your patients' secrets.

Why did you turn away from the medical profession? Or if you haven't, what was it that drew you into the life of the adventurer? What do you think of the oath, or other doctors?

Specialist

Each doctor must choose a field of specialization to practice within the broader art of medicine.

d6	Specialization
1	Diagnostics
2	Apothecary
3	Surgery
4	Bone Setting
5	Therapy
6	Research

Skill Proficiencies: Medicine, Investigation
Tool Proficiencies: Medicine Kit
Languages: One of your choice
Equipment: Doctor's Tools, 2-man tent, bedroll, blanket, Book (About anatomy, disease, apothecary, or surgery), common clothes, five bars of soap, a belt pouch containing 5 gp.

Feature: Burden of Life

Due to your vow, you are expected to cure the ill, regardless of morals or prejudice, even if they are your enemy. Likewise, it is considered a horrid evil to intentionally kill a doctor for no reason. As such, intelligent enemies are less likely to target you, provided they are not overwhelmingly evil or lack a code of honor. Your patients who are enemies will even stay their hand, not attacking you directly while they are under your care. Though... who's to say what happens after they leave your care?

Restored individuals may be grateful, or feel some form of life-debt to you. Enemies may repay you by specifically choosing not to kill you, or they may give free information; a scout you once saved may turn a blind eye to your presence.

Provided you stay true to your vow as best as you can, you can make use of any hospital or medical facility - typically located in churches, noble estates, universities, and other places of higher learning - as temporary residence for yourself, your patient or patients, and your companions if there is room for them. Doctors will put you up at a lifestyle one step below their own if you can maintain a good relationship with them.

However, if ever you are proven to have broken your vow, you will be fully and publicly discredited as a doctor, and other doctors who pay attention to medical society will recognize you as such. You and all who are with you will be turned away from mundane medicine and the places it is provided. Because you swore on your life, breaking your vow is akin to a personal death sentence, though no doctor true to his vows is free to exact it upon you. Even so, more enlightened nations are likely to have laws regarding the treatment of doctors and their vows... and enlightened does not necessarily mean "kind" or "gentle".

Suggested Characteristics

Doctors may come from many walks of life, but all became enrolled in some place of higher learning, or at least were tutored by a renowned doctor, eventually swearing the Hippocratic oath - and that oath is not a light load to bear. Doctors often show their true colors under extreme stress, whether it makes them more studious, intense, and passionate, or clinical, intellectual, and unusually calm.

Many are troubled by harrowing events they bore witness to. Some are shockingly pragmatic, with an "it may not be pretty, but you'll live" approach to problems. Many are seemingly tireless, hard-working individuals. Some can be inspiring souls, with a deep appreciation not only for life itself, but for the people they keep alive as well. There is much debate among doctors as to just what the oath means, and what tenets have priority in any given situation.

d8	Personality Trait
1	All I think about is saving lives, or I dwell on lives that have been lost that I could have saved.
2	I practice in the name of my religion, nation, or clan.
3	I am cold and calculating in my every word and action, even when furious or frightened.
4	When the bodies hit the floor, my hands go into autopilot.
5	I consider magical healers and healing either to be cheating and unaccountable, or an integral future counterpart of a greater medical art.
6	I am waging a personal war on death itself.
7	I am entranced and inspired by the brilliance and glory of the living body.
8	I am actively involved in the medical society and engage in theoretical discourse and debate.

d6	Ideal
1	**Life.** I was put in this world to protect and save life. (Good)
2	**Oath.** I swore my oath, and now I must live by its tenets. (Lawful)
3	**Vigilantism.** No man can dictate who shall die, when, or how! (Chaotic)
4	**Profit.** Is it really too much to ask that all who come to me suffering also come bearing compensation? (Evil)
5	**Survival.** We are all in this together, for better or for worse. (Neutral)
6	**Right.** Everyone deserves to live. (Neutral)

d6	Bond
1	I owe everything to my home village/clan, for pooling their resources to have me educated.
2	I was pushed, or encouraged, into the field by my parents, one of whom may have been a doctor.
3	My professor is the most important person in the world to me.
4	My patients are my everything- losing one of them is like dying, but it never ends.
5	I took up the profession because someone close to me died of something treatable.
6	I started my training alone from texts I obtained by my own means.

d6	Flaw
1	I took the vow not realizing its full implications.
2	No one can know that I have broken my vow.
3	I feel contempt for many of my patients.
4	I think I am better than other doctors, and other people in general.
5	Sometimes I go too far in my search for knowledge.
6	I am frightened/sickened by human suffering.

Variant Doctor: Veterinarian

Your specialization and training still stand, but instead of treating people, your art is focused on our fuzzy friends. Exchange Investigation for Animal Handling or Nature.

Animals who have been healed do not behave the same way people do. Some more intelligent creatures, such as wolves, may be capable of feeling gratitude, but have limited ability to express such. Monsters however, true to their name, are usually incapable of such emotion and will likely just attack the moment they recover. Other doctors may not take you as seriously as you deserve, but anyone who has an important animal, such as a knight's steed or a caster's familiar, will have deep respect for you, for even acknowledging that their animal is worth saving.



Background: Law Enforcement:

As a child, you dreamed of serving your city with pride and protecting it from evil and injustice. When you were old enough, you headed to your recruiting station to begin the training to become a member of law enforcement. This background is suitable for uniformed police, military or federal police, government agents, and special forces.

Skill Proficiencies: Athletics, Insight
Additional Proficiency: Sidearms
Languages: One additional language of your choice
Equiptment: Light pistol, two full magazines, and a police uniform

Feature: Civil Ranking

Being a officer of the law, you gain privileges suitable to your station. If you are within the city that you served in, patrol officers are likely to follow your orders, within logical reason.

Outside of your jurisdiction, you have advantage on Charisma (Persuasion) checks and Charisma saving throws (again, within reason) against law enforcement of equal or lesser rank. You must show your badge, thus identifying yourself as a member of law enforcement, to use this feature.

When choosing this background, roll a d6, or choose a rank from 1-6 from the options below. Players cannot begin at a rank of 7 or higher. Rankings are as follows:

- **Rank 10:** Chief of Police, Superintendent, Director, or Commissioner
- **Rank 9:** Deputy/Assistant Chief, Superintendent, Director or Commissioner
- **Rank 8:** Major
- **Rank 7:** Captain or Commander
- **Rank 6:** Lieutenant
- **Rank 5:** Staff Sergeant, Sergeant First Class, First Sergeant, Master Sergeant, or Sergeant Major
- **Rank 4:** Sergeant
- **Rank 3:** Corporal or Senior/Master
- **Rank 2:** Trooper or Patrolman
- **Rank 1:** Cadet, Recruit, Trainee, or Probationary



d8	Personality Trait
1	I always wear my uniform outside to show that I am here to keep people safe.
2	I am the law. I get to say who walks free.
3	I look for clues and try my best to get the crook.
4	I love making people happy, as long as I am also keeping them safe.
5	I never trust a criminal. Ever.
6	I enjoy a good chase. My heart beating, my legs pumping... It's what I live for.
7	If I'm paid, I'm happy. It doesn't matter who paid me.
8	I will give everything I have to save my people, including my life.

d6	Ideal
1	**Truth.** The duty of law enforcement is to seek and lay bare the truth. (Any)
2	**Justice.** I won't sleep until I catch every dirty criminal I see. (Lawful)
3	**Law.** What good is the law if it isn't followed? (Good)
4	**Glory.** I want money and fame more than anything, even if I have to get my hands dirty. (Evil)
5	**Merciless.** I don't care about the means; as long as the criminal is behind bars it's okay with me. (Chaotic)
6	**Aspiration.** I want to follow in the footsteps of the officer who saved my life. I'll do anything to be like them. (Any)

d6	Bond
1	I work to put food on the table and I will work extra just to make sure I do.
2	I truly enjoy being a part of the justice system.
3	These people are my purpose. I can't save them I've failed them.
4	This is just one way that I show my deep devotion to the god I worship.
5	I owe my life to a rookie or officer.
6	I am always on the hunt for a promotion.

d6	Flaw
1	I get so caught up in work I don't pay attention to the real world.
2	I will beat the answers out of anyone who don't give me what I want.
3	I get drunk on the job but it keeps me going.
4	I have trouble following orders from my superiors.
5	I put too much trust in my fellow officers even dirty ones.
6	I don't make mistakes, I just do things differently.

Background: Mercenary

As a mercenary your services were for hire to anyone who could afford you. What drove you to be a soldier of fortune? Was it to escape poverty? Was it the thrill of battle? Or was it simply that fighting was all you knew growing up?

Who was your battle company, or did you work alone? What made you give it up... or are you still for hire? Did you make any allies or enemies along the way? What wars or battles were you involved in? What were the consequences? Lost allies? War crime charges?

Skill Proficiencies: Intimidation, Perception
Tool Proficiencies: One type of gaming set, Vehicles (land)
Equipment: Proof of the first contract you completed, a set of common clothes, one gaming set of choice, a belt pouch containing 10 gp

Feature: Hired Blade

You are a soldier of fortune, a fighter who sells his services to the highest bidder. You roam towns and cities in search of a place where your unique set of talents are useful; whether for a lord hunting a group of bandits, or a local barkeep tired of the goblin infestation in his cellar, you can always find some work if you look hard enough. The job itself doesn't matter, so long as you get paid - at least, that's what people tend to think. Sometimes, the jobs you find tend to be of the seedier sort, giving you the choice and the problem of figuring a way to compromise between your ethics and your job.

Suggested Characteristics

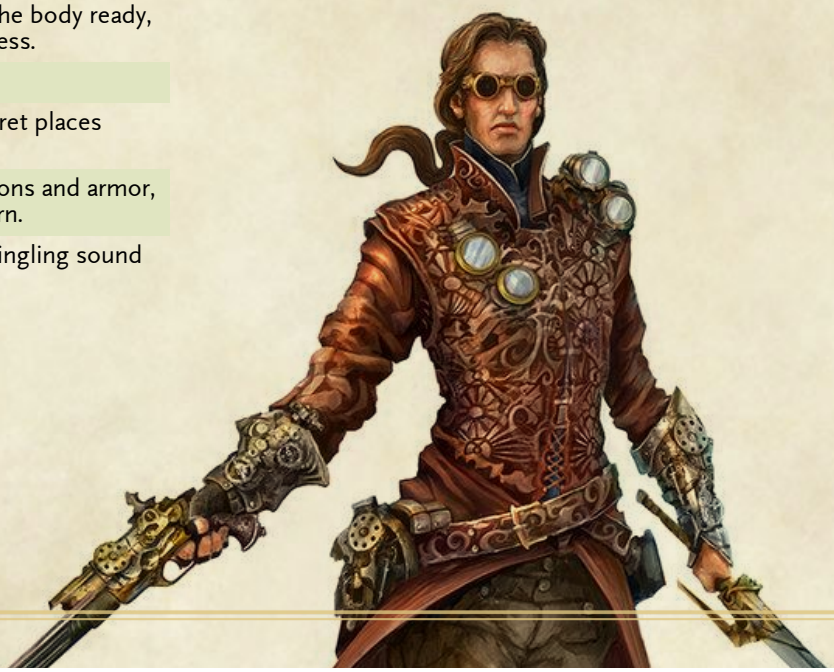
You are a mercenary who hunted down your employers' enemies for coin. Were you happy in this life? What made you leave it behind to become an adventurer? Did you leave it at all, or is adventuring just another way of putting food on the table?

d8	Personality Trait
1	I like to show off, particularly if there's a chance at another job.
2	I am always gregarious and cheerful, no matter the situation, as long as my pockets are full.
3	To me, the whisper of steel and the clash of weapons is just as pleasing as any amount of gold.
4	I always train because training leaves the body ready, even in a moment of respite or weakness.
5	I hold myself to a strict code of ideals.
6	I keep my personal possessions in secret places which known only to me.
7	I take special care to protect my weapons and armor, for I know they will protect me in return.
8	I refuse to lift a finger until I hear the jingling sound of coins.

d6	Ideal
1	**Golden Pockets.** I fight for money, and nothing else. (Neutral)
2	**Great Publicity.** I will be known for my deeds, sooner rather than later. (Any)
3	**Power or Death.** In my line of profession, the strong live and the weak starve. (Evil)
4	**Honorbound.** I never break my promises. Ever. (Lawful)
5	**War and Crime.** Whenever chaos flourishes, so too does my work. (Chaotic)
6	**Vigilante.** I am a sellsword who swings his weapon only against those who deserve it. (Good)

d6	Bond
1	I became a mercenary to support my family, who would have probably starved in a slum somewhere if not for me.
2	I fight for a lover that knows little if not nothing of me.
3	I was inspired by a great hero to become a mercenary.
4	I treat my valued comrades like brothers, and I will let no insult or injury fall upon them.
5	I am protecting something of great importance to me by keeping it a secret... so you'd better forget what you just heard.
6	I never disrespect an employer, as long as they never disrespect me or stop giving me money.

d6	Flaw
1	I'll do anything for coin, damn the consequences.
2	As much as I pretend to love fighting, I secretly hate hurting others.
3	I have crippling debts that my work barely pays off.
4	I never fail at my tasks, even if I have to resort to less honourable means to complete them.
5	I would send an innocent to face his death if it means I will win the fight.
6	Someone powerful will do anything to have my head, so I seek to take his or her head first.



Background: Merchant

Whether you spent a few years as an apprentice or you were self-taught, you know your way around a marketplace. It's like a second home to you, where you can talk for hours on end and you know exactly what you can and can't do.

Skill Proficiencies: Persuasion, Insight
Tool Proficiencies: One gaming set of your choice, cartographer's tools
Languages: Two of your choice
Equipment: An item you were unable to sell, a few minor souvenirs from places you've been to, a backpack, a set of traveler's clothes, and a belt pouch containing 50 gp.

Feature: Soft Skills

Your know exactly what to say and do to close a sale. Once per day, you can use this feature to gain advantage on a single Charisma check that involves negotiating a deal with others.

> ***Variant Feature: Hard Negotiation.*** This is not role-playing. When attempting to sell a magical item (as detailed in *Xanathar's Guide to Everything*'s downtime rules), you get a +5 bonus to the Charisma (Persuasion) check required for the Magic Item Offer.

Suggested Characteristics

Travelling around and interacting with people shaped how you act around people, consider the following traits.

d8	Personality Trait
1	I am very protective of my merchandise.
2	I'm very talkative, and I like to interact with people.
3	I like to take notes about my customer's appearance, disposition, and items they have on hand.
4	I talk very quickly, and always cut to the chase.
5	I like to joke around and tell stories.
6	I speak in an unusual dialect.
7	I give my two cents on everything.
8	I like to dabble in many different cultures. It's all so interesting!

d6	Ideal
1	**Charity.** I'm doing what I do so others can benefit from my goods. (Good)
2	**Greed.** I'm doing this for money. Nothing else matters. (Evil)
3	**People.** I love to interact with people. That's the most important thing. (Neutral)
4	**Change.** Change makes the world go round. It's everywhere and needs to be embraced. (Chaotic)
5	**Fairness.** Everyone deserves equal opportunity. (Lawful)
6	**Aspiration.** I hope my life and my wares propel me to greatness. (Any)

d6	Bond
1	My business is my life. I must always make a sale.
2	I am being pursued by a crime boss I can never repay.
3	All I am trying to do is provide for my family.
4	I will do anything for the right amount of gold.
5	Seeing the world is as valuable as gold, I must see it all.
6	My culture and my past keep me on the road, always looking for the next sale.

d6	Flaw
1	The only thing I trust is gold.
2	No amount of gold is worth my life, I will run when in danger.
3	Making a profit is more important than honesty or integrity.
4	People's feelings mean little to me, they are worth only as much as the gold in their pockets.
5	The mere mention of gold throws all my judgement out the window.
6	If there's a bet, then I'm in. All in. Double or nothing. Don't tell me the odds, just roll the dice!



Background: Philosopher

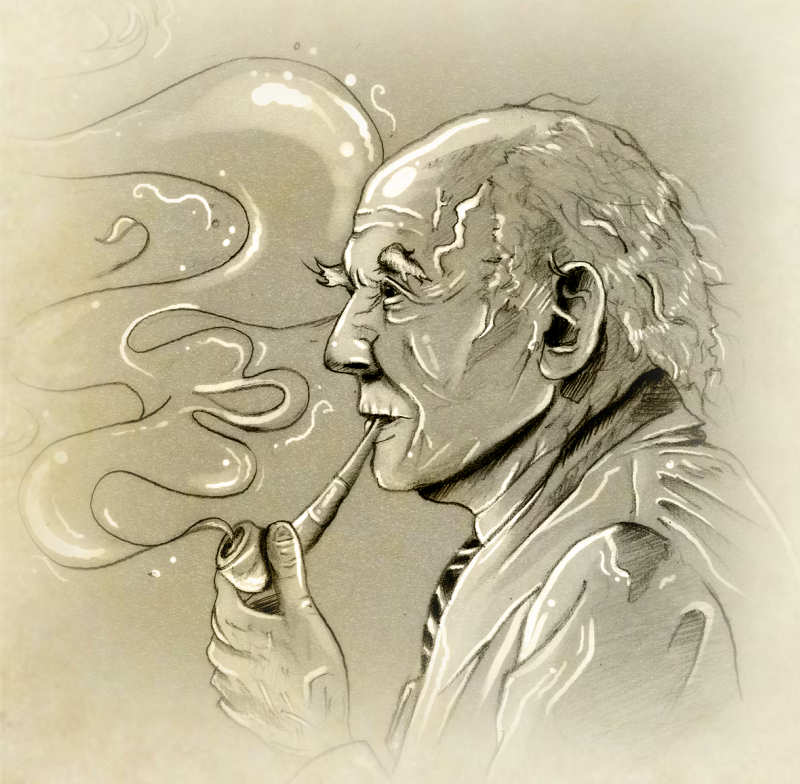
By u/Ezfi

You have dedicated yourself to the pursuit of answers to life's most difficult questions, ones of existence, morality and meaning, and you have made a name for yourself doing so. Perhaps you were privileged and classically trained, inheriting your theories from the world's greatest minds and making them your own. Or maybe you started the quest for truth from nothing, forming your philosophy by debating with any friend or stranger who would entertain you, and your conclusions have only recently received wide attention and acclaim. After spending a lifetime in the realm of thought, it may be surprising to see you pursue the active and practical life of an adventurer.

Skill Proficiencies: History, Insight
Languages: Two of your choice
Equipment: A book of your thoughts, a quill, a jar of black ink, an small trinket that once gave you a philosophical revelation, a set of common clothes, and a belt pouch containing 10 gp.

Feature: Debate Ethics

Among those who study philosophy, including cultured nobles, academics and other philosophers, there is a chance that at least some of them have heard of your work. Those who respect philosophy will assume you to be a reasonably wise and intelligent person, and they will be more likely to listen to your advice. Using your reputation and experience in debate, you may be able to convince these people that an act which seems evil, wrong, or morally questionable at first glance is, in fact, perfectly fine. While they are not guaranteed to agree with you, they are more likely to give your arguments serious consideration.



Philosophies

d20	Philosophy
1	**Solipsism.** Knowledge of anything outside one's own specific mind is unjustified. The external world and other minds cannot be known and might not exist.
2	**Determinism.** Every event, including thoughts and behavior, decision and action, is determined by an unbroken chain of prior occurrences.
3	**Utilitarianism.** The moral worth of an action is solely determined by its contribution to overall utility, that is, what creates the most net happiness.
4	**Hedonism.** Pleasure is the only intrinsic good. Actions can be evaluated in terms of how much pleasure they produce.
5	**Positivism.** Knowledge can only come from positive affirmation through a strict scientific method.
6	**Absurdism.** Any effort to find meaning in the universe will ultimately fail (and, hence, is absurd) because no such meaning exists.
7	**Objectivism.** Certain acts are objectively right or wrong.
8	**Relativism.** No belief can have absolute truth, having value only within a certain context or frame of reference.
9	**Nihilism.** Life is without objective meaning, purpose, value or truth.
10	**Existentialism.** All philosophical thought must begin with the experiences of the individual, and it is up to them to give meaning to their own existence.
11	**Rationalism.** The criterion of the truth is not sensory, but intellectual and deductive.
12	**Stoicism.** Emotional and physical self-control leads to inner peace and strength, allowing one to live a happier life.
13	**Aestheticism.** Our main efforts in life should be on creating and enjoying beauty, in all of its forms.
14	**Collectivism.** The greater good is more important than any individual.
15	**Egalitarianism.** All individuals should be treated as equals.
16	**Constructivism.** Reality, and the methods we use to understand it, are subjective constructions rather than an objective reading of events.
17	**Naturalism.** The supernatural and the natural are indistinguishable and can be studied with the same methods.
18	**Finalism.** Any event is defined by a pre-set final outcome, and all events leading up to the outcome are shaped by it.
19	**Cynicism.** Selfless qualities like altruism, honest and virtue do not exist. People are only driven by self-interest.
20	I haven't settled on a philosophy.

Personal Philosophy

After spending a lifetime asking and pondering, you have developed a personal philosophical stance. Choose one from the Philosophies table or roll on it to determine what your character is mainly focused on.

Suggested Characteristics

Philosophers are highly concerned with thoughts, theories, and abstract concepts, and tend to view the world in a way that is tinted by this fixation. They may embrace the world around them as a fascinating manifestation of the universe's inner workings, or they may shun it in favor of their internal experience.

d8	Personality Trait
1	I never stop asking questions. Ever.
2	I am absent minded and easily distracted.
3	I spend several hours each day in quiet introspection.
4	I love seeing how other respond to paradoxes and strange thought experiments.
5	The philosophical conclusions of common people are just as valuable as those from established academics.
6	I enjoy the challenge of explaining complex philosophical concepts in terms that a layman can understand.
7	I am unflappable in the face of tragedy, analyzing the situation in a calm, academic manner.
8	Everything can be seen as a metaphor for the deeper meaning of life.

d6	Ideal
1	**Truth.** There are answers out there and I intend to find them. (Any)
2	**Indoctrination.** I won't be happy until everyone believes exactly what I believe. (Lawful)
3	**Virtue.** What good is a moral system if you don't put it into practice? (Good)
4	**Justification.** I use philosophy to excuse my cruel impulses. (Evil)
5	**Rebellion.** I like thinking and believing differently than everyone else. (Chaotic)
6	**Aspiration.** I want to be like the great philosophers that I look up to. (Any)

d6	Bond
1	I have written a book, paper or manifesto on my philosophy and I want to promote it.
2	I need to find meaning in my life.
3	There is a living philosopher that I look up to more than anyone, and I dream of meeting them.
4	My philosophy is just one way that I show my deep devotion to the god I worship.
5	I owe my theories and success to the school of philosophy that trained me.
6	I am always on the hunt for evidence that my philosophy is the correct one.

d6	Flaw
1	I get so caught up in thought experiments that I don't pay attention to the real world.
2	My philosophy comes with implications that trouble me deeply, and I fear accepting them.
3	I get personally offended when my views are challenged.
4	I'm a hypocrite who can't follow my own beliefs.
5	Practical problems always stump me.
6	I'm not wrong, I just think on such a high abstract level that no one else gets it.

Background: Slave

u/Moses_The_Wise

You are some kind of slave or indentured servant, or you are or were controlled entirely by another person or group of people. You don't have to be a slave in the traditional sense; an abused and isolated child, a tortured prisoner, or an underpaid servant or worker, any or all of these people could take this background.

Were you a field worker, sweating to bring in harvests? Or were you a house slave who took care of the master and his/her household? Maybe you worked in something similar to a sugar plantation, where the work was highly dangerous and often lethal.

You can choose whether you bought your freedom, were freed by someone else or even your master/mistress, escaped and are on the run, or if you still actually serve them but are travelling on your own for one reason or another.

Skill Proficiencies: Deception, Intimidation
Languages: One of your choice, which you are illiterate in.
Equipment: A pair of manacles you at one point wore, A simple memento from your family or a fellow slave, something you used to do your job as a slave, 5 gp.

Specialty

As a slave, you had a job to do - whether you liked it or not. Roll a d8 on the table to determine that job.

d8	Job
1	Maid/Butler
2	Field Worker
3	Concubine
4	Fisher
5	Miner
6	Assistant
7	Gardener
8	Cook

Feature: Grovel

You are used to bowing, scraping and apologizing for even slight offenses. While more prideful slaves are loathe to do it, you can earn enough through begging to live a Poor lifestyle in most cities, and you can usually find someone who is willing to take you in - though there may be a price, and it may not be gold.

Suggested Characteristics

Slaves will have been shaped by the way they were treated, and what kind of work they did. Their treatment and their relationships to both other slaves as well as their masters/mistresses affect their mannerisms and ideals. Their flaws might be a side effect of the trauma of their slavery.

d8	Personality Trait
1	I am shy, rarely speak, and avoid eye contact.
2	My manners are spot on; I'm always polite and respectful.
3	I'm sick of biting my tongue, and am purposefully rude to those I dislike.
4	I am rather uncouth, with little understanding of social etiquette.
5	Sometimes I misinterpret requests as orders.
6	I don't take commands from anyone.
7	I am subservient and servile.
8	I prefer to be in charge.

d6	Ideal
1	**Subservient.** Just follow the rules and do what you're told, and everything will be alright. (Lawful)
2	**Release.** No one should suffer slavery as I have. (Good)
3	**Freedom.** Everyone should be allowed to do as they please. (Chaotic)
4	**Autonomy.** I just want to live my life undisturbed. (Neutral)
5	**Power.** It would be nice to be the one holding the whip for once. (Evil)
6	**Wander.** I wish to see the world that I've never been able to see. (Any)

d6	Bond
1	My master treated me well, and I consider them to be my family.
2	I ran away from my old master; they're still looking for me.
3	I am still in service to my master.
4	Slavery separated me from my family; perhaps I'll find them again.
5	Someone I love is still a slave; I want to free them.
6	I owe my life, and my freedom, to the one who freed me.

d6	Flaw
1	I am terrified of authority figures.
2	I often will just do what others tell me to.
3	I refuse to listen to anyone else, or take any advice.
4	My scars, both mental and physical, still cause me great pain.
5	I have little pity for slaves that have accepted their fate.
6	I have an extreme fear of confinement and punishment.

